

He even ate the cookies we left by the fireplace and his reindeers ate the carrots we left outside.” The circle is complete, and the story is airtight.

Human beings have strong preferences for coherent stories and often build powerful narratives to help interpret complex situations. In our daughters' cases, the impossible physics of the Santa story will cause the story to break down over time, but the powerful Santa Claus narrative will likely extend well beyond what many would consider its “rational life.” The Santa Claus story is one that appeals to many young children,⁴ but it is not just children who suffer from a strong belief in stories; adults are highly susceptible as well.

The basis for our persistent belief in stories, in spite of evidence suggesting a story is unbelievable, has perplexed researchers for many years. Consider the range of fantastic human superstitions, which are pervasive in society. The behavioral psychologist B. F. Skinner and several colleagues demonstrated that our innate need for superstition is deeply ingrained in our primal brains.⁵ To make the point, Skinner studied one of the more powerful brains in the animal kingdom—the pigeon.

Skinner put hungry pigeons in a cage and dispensed food pellets to them every five seconds. Now, as we all know from our urban sidewalk experiences, pigeons will naturally wander around any space looking for food, and will do so in predictably pigeon-like ways. One pigeon might step to the left and then step to the right; another pigeon might jump, land, and then jump again. In the experiment, following these random movements a food pellet will appear, consistent with a five-second release pattern. After a few rounds of engaging in the same random activities and earning a series of food pellets, each pigeon develops an internal story: Some particular deliberate action it took in the cage is causing food pellets to pop out of the feeder. Pigeons that randomly kick to the right start to believe that kicking to the right releases the pellet. Pigeons that kick to the left continue the same pattern with the opposite foot, and so on.

Amazingly, once a pigeon establishes a superstition, it is exceedingly difficult to train the pigeon out of the story. Skinner attempts to give the pigeons evidence that their superstition is worthless (e.g., only releasing pellets when the right foot is NOT kicked), but the pigeons continue with